

Prologue:

A Note from Ireland

You can't bring up the stock market these days with-out analyzing the events of October 16–20, 1987. It was one of the most unusual weeks I've ever experienced. More than a year later, and looking back on it with some dispassion, I can begin to separate the sensational ballyhoo from the incidents of lasting importance. What's worth remembering I remember as follows:

- On October 16, a Friday, my wife—Carolyn—and I spent a delightful day driving through County Cork, Ireland. I rarely take vacations, so the fact that I was traveling at all was extraordinary in itself.

- I didn't even once stop to visit the headquarters of a publicly traded company. Generally I'll detour 100 miles in any direction to get the latest word on sales, inventories, and earnings, but there didn't seem to be an S&P report or a balance sheet anywhere within 250 miles of us here.

- We went to Blarney Castle, where the legendary Blarney stone is lodged inconveniently in a parapet at the top of the building, several stories above the ground. You get to lie on your back, wiggle your way across the metal grating that comes between you and a fatal drop, and then while gripping a guardrail for emotional support, you kiss the legendary stone. Kissing the Blarney stone is as big a thrill as they say—especially the getting out alive.

- We recovered from the Blarney stone by spending a quiet weekend playing golf—at Waterville on Saturday and at Dooks on Sunday—and driving along the beautiful Ring of Kerry.

- On Monday, October 19, I faced the ultimate challenge, which demanded every bit of intelligence and stamina that I could muster—the eighteen holes at the Killeen course in Killarney, one of the most difficult courses in the world.

- After packing the clubs into the car, I drove with Carolyn out on the Dingle peninsula to the seaside resort of that name, where we checked into the Sceilig Hotel. I must have been tired. I never left the hotel room for the entire afternoon.

- That evening we dined with friends, Elizabeth and Peter Callery, at a famous seafood place called Doyle's. The next day, the 20th, we flew home.

THOSE PETTY UPSETS

Of course, I've left out a few petty upsets. In hindsight they hardly seem